



THE EPIC: INTRODUCTION TO THE ODYSSEY

GUIDED NOTES FOR REVIEW



odysseus: we now set out on our odyssey.

sailor: [raising hand] what's an odyssey?

odysseus: a long journey named after the only survivor.

sailor: oh ok wait what.



DEFINITION AND SOME HISTORY OF THE EPIC



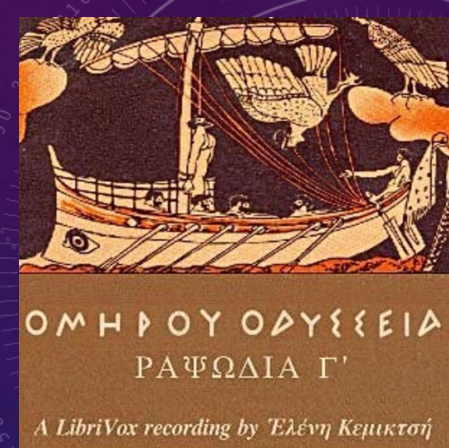
A long narrative poem that recounts the adventures of an epic hero. Typically one derived from ancient oral tradition, narrating the deeds and adventures of heroic or legendary figures or the history of a nation.

The oldest epic recognized is the Epic of Gilgamesh (c. 2500–1300 BCE), which was recorded in ancient Sumer during the Neo-Sumerian Empire. The poem details the exploits of Gilgamesh, the king of Uruk.

Beowulf is a heroic poem, considered the highest achievement of Old English literature and the earliest European epic.

THE ODYSSEY:

- The Odyssey is an epic poem in 24 books traditionally attributed to the ancient Greek poet **Homer**. The poem is the story of Odysseus, king of Ithaca, who wanders for **10 years** (although the action of the poem covers only the final six weeks) trying to get home after the Trojan War.
- The people of ancient Greece who first experienced the Odyssey heard it sung in a live performance. The poet, or another performer, used epic similes, epithets, and allusions to help keep the audience entertained.



THE BASICS:

The poem is the story of Odysseus, king of Ithaca, who wanders for 10 years (although the action of the poem covers only the final six weeks) trying to get home after the Trojan War. On his return, he is recognized only by his faithful dog and a nurse. With the help of his son, *Telemachus*, Odysseus destroys the insistent *suitors* of his faithful wife, *Penelope*, and several of her maids who had fraternized with the suitors and reestablishes himself in his kingdom.

FUN FACTS:



- The Iliad is the model for the WAR EPIC
- The Odyssey is the model for the JOURNEY EPIC

Can you think of “epic” stories that fit either of these categories?

HOW AN APPLE STARTED IT ALL...

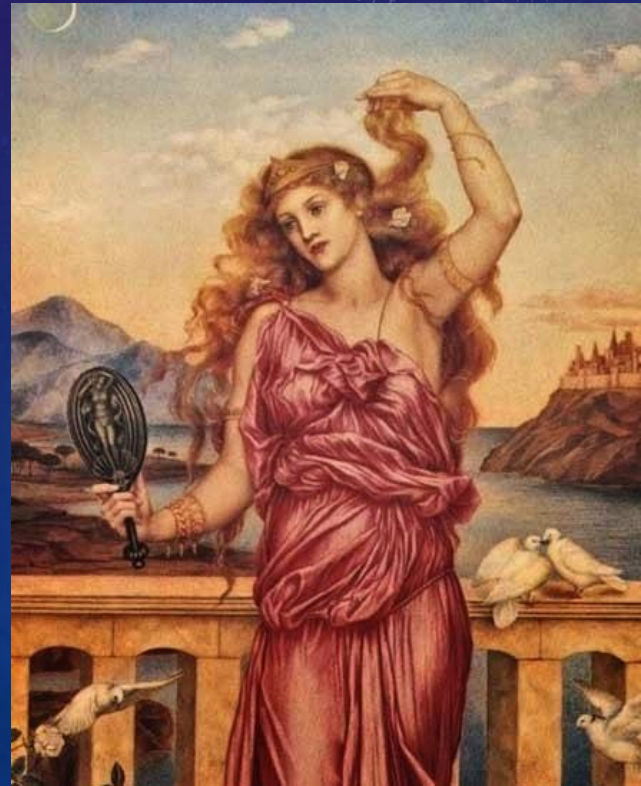
Three goddesses claimed the apple: Hera, Athena and Aphrodite. They asked Zeus to judge which of them was fairest, and eventually he, reluctant to favor any claim himself, declared that Paris, a Trojan mortal, would judge.

Hera offered to make him king of Europe and Asia, Athena offered wisdom and skill in war, and Aphrodite, offered the world's most beautiful woman ([Euripides](#), *Andromache*, l.284, *Helena* l. 676). This was [Helen](#) of [Sparta](#), wife of the Greek king [Menelaus](#). Paris accepted Aphrodite's gift and awarded the apple to her, receiving Helen as well as the enmity of the Greeks and especially of Hera.



THE GREEKS' EXPEDITION TO RETRIEVE HELEN FROM PARIS IN TROY IS THE MYTHOLOGICAL BASIS OF THE TROJAN WAR.

- Helen becomes known as “The Face That Launched a Thousand Ships...”



PRE-ILIAD

Odysseus did not want to leave home to fight a war over an unfaithful woman so:

- He pretended to be insane when Menelaus and Agamemnon came for him. He dressed up as a peasant and began sowing the field with salt.
- The kings were smart and threw Telemachus in front of the oncoming plow
- Odysseus revealed his sanity by swerving the plow to avoid his son



RELATIONSHIPS TO GODS

Homer concerned with the relationship between humans and the gods.

Often portrayed gods as heroes' alter egos – was a reflection of the hero's best or worst quality

Examples:

- Athena (goddess of wisdom) – Odysseus' protector – Odysseus is wise
- Poseidon (sea god – known for his arrogance and brutishness) – Odysseus' adversary – Odysseus can be violent and cruel



GODS CONTINUED: IN THE ODYSSEY THEY TOOK SIDES- TEAM TROJAN

- Aphrodite sides with the Trojans since Paris picked her to win the apple, deciding she was the most beautiful. Aphrodite also awards Helen to Paris as a prize.
- Ares is a “boyfriend” of Aphrodite. He sides with her. He’s also generally into bloodshed, so he causes a lot of ruckus during the war. He’s seen as a coward during many episodes of fighting.
- Artemis is offended when Agamemnon, a Greek king, wounds one of her sacred animals. She sets the wind against the Greeks, delaying their travel to Troy.
- Apollo, the twin of Artemis, sides with his sister. Further, he is angry that the Greeks dishonored one of his temples during the sack of Troy.



SIDES WITH GREEKS:

- Hera loses out on the golden apple, and she subsequently hates Paris and the Trojans.
- Athena is the patron goddess of the Greeks. She also admires Odysseus specifically for his wisdom.
- Poseidon is all about grudges. Though he becomes angry with Odysseus during his return from the Trojan War, during the war itself, he supports the Greeks due to his grudge against the Trojans, who refused to actually pay him and Apollo after they constructed the walls of Troy. Then Odysseus goes and offers additional insult to his son, the cyclops....

NEUTRAL TERRITORY: ZEUS AND HERMES



Zeus tends to try and stay “neutral” in conflicts among the gods in order to keep his hands directly clean. He does not get as involved as the other gods during the Trojan War- he does “help” Odysseus later in his journey.

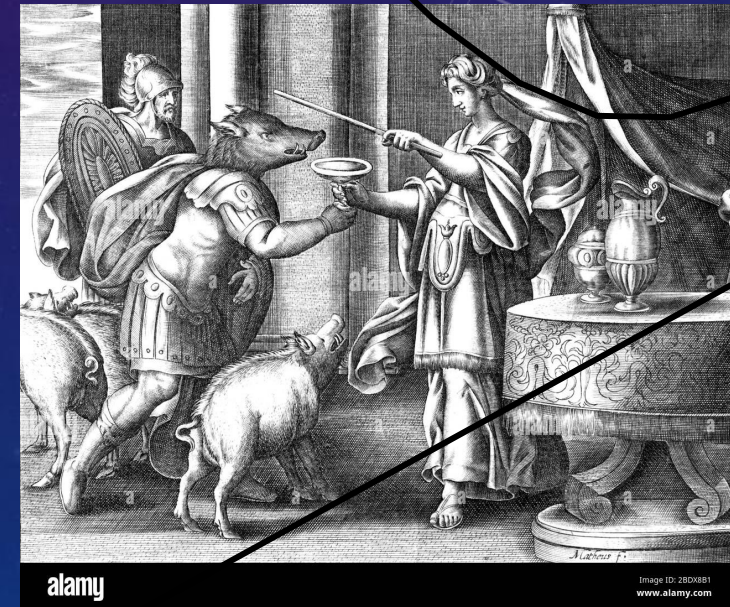
Hermes: Messenger who stays fairly neutral during the war. He acts as a helper to Odysseus during his journey after Athena asks Zeus to help him get home.

END OF THE WAR:
ODYSSEUS ORDERS HIS MEN TO BUILD A GIANT
HORSE, AND TO PRETEND TO “GIVE UP” AND
DEPART FOR HOME. HOWEVER, MEN ARE
SECRETLY HIDDEN INSIDE. THE TROJANS PULL THE
HORSE INSIDE THEIR WALLS, AND AFTER DARK, THE
GREEK SOLDIERS COME POURING OUT AND TAKE
THE CITY TO WIN!



MONSTERS, WITCHES AND DEATH WHIRLPOOLS: THE NON-HUMANS IN THE STORY

- Cyclops
- Circe the Witch
- Sirens
- Scylla
- Charybdis



ADDITIONAL WEIRDOS:



The Lotus Eaters



Tiresias, the blind seer



Sacred Cattle of Sun God

THE SET UP:

- Invocation of the Muses:
An invocation begins the epic poem and serves as a prologue to the events to come. A prayer or address is made to one of the nine muses of Greco-Roman mythology. The poet asks for the inspiration, skill, knowledge, or the right emotion to finish a poem worthy of his subject matter.

